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SELMA

In 1965 the issue is the right to vote and the place is Selma, Alabama. In Selma, we see a classic pattern of disenfranchisement typical of the Southern Black Belt areas where Negroes are in the majority.

FEBRUARY 1, 1965
King is jailed with more than two hundred others after voting rights march in Selma, Alabama

FEBRUARY 26
Jimmie Lee Jackson dies after being shot by police during demonstration in Marion, Alabama

MARCH 7
Voting rights marchers are beaten at Edmund Pettus Bridge

MARCH 11
Rev. James Reeb dies after beating by white racists

MARCH 25
Selma-to-Montgomery march concludes with address by King; hours afterward, Klan night riders kill Viola Gregg Liuzzo while she transports marchers back to Selma

When I was coming from Scandinavia in December 1964, I stopped by to see President Johnson and we talked about a lot of things, but finally we started talking about voting.

And he said, “Martin, you’re right about that. I’m going to do it eventually, but I can’t get a voting rights bill through in this session of Congress.” He said, “Now, there’s some other bills that I have here that I want to get through in my Great Society program, and I think in the long run they’ll help Negroes more, as much as a voting rights bill. And let’s get those through and then the other.”

I said, “Well, you know, political reform is as necessary as anything if we’re going to solve all these other problems.”